
June 9-10, 2026
Fifty-Fourth Biennial Convention
of the Minnesota District

President's Report

Therefore, if anyone is in Christ, the new creation has come: The old has gone, the new is here! All this is from God, who reconciled us to himself through Christ and gave us the ministry of reconciliation: that God was reconciling the world to himself in Christ, not counting people's sins against them. And he has committed to us the message of reconciliation. ~ 2 Corinthians 5:17-19 (NIV 2011)

Reconciled Reconcilers

“Never get between two fighting dogs. Doing so you risk being bitten by both.” That’s sound advice not just when dealing with pets but with people, too. Those who seek to make peace between two hostile human factions may find themselves attacked by both sides. Such was Martin Luther’s experience when he attempted to mediate the conflict between the peasants and nobility during the German Peasants’ War (1524-1525).

The world’s most significant conflict spans more than two years or evening 100 years. It was initiated in Eden. The truth was exchanged for a lie. The created turned against their Creator. For millennia sinful humanity has been raging against its holy God.

With a word, our Maker could have and still can crush his enemies. Yet, he chose a different path toward ending the conflict—reconciliation. Before the foundation of the earth, God planned for his Son to stand between sinners and God’s just judgment. Jesus received blows and condemnation from both parties. Earthly powers condemned and abused him. God counted our sin as Christ’s and made him pay the price. On Calvary God’s righteous anger toward us was extinguished and his demand of holiness was met for us in Christ. The result was God’s reconciliation with every hostile sinner, a peace with God personally possessed through faith in Christ alone.

There is only one power in heaven and on earth capable of transforming humanity’s inborn hostility against God into love and trust in God—the message of Christ-crucified. By its power the old hostility in us is gone. New life, new trust and new love for God have come.

That transforming message has now been entrusted to us. We are God’s ambassadors. As our heavenly Father sent his Son to make reconciliation, we are now sent by him to announce reconciliation in Christ to the world. Since the unbelieving world remains hostile to God, it will

often sink its teeth into God's ambassadors. But we gladly embrace the risk. We accept wounds of all kinds. We spare no expense. We are God's reconciled reconcilers. Through us frail messengers God delights in recreating his image in the lost. To this end, we partner as individual saints in congregations and individual congregations in our synod. May the Lord bless our efforts to remain reconciled to God through his Word and to bring his reconciliation to world.

About this report

According to our bylaws, *At each regular convention of the district the president shall submit a written report on the activities of his office during the past biennium.*

On the pages immediately below, you will find a report on district presidium goals, activities related to the past biennium and the work planned for the coming biennium. In my oral presentation I won't have time to speak to everything. If able, please read this report in advance. I will happily provide clarifications and address questions.

WHAT WE'VE DONE

Your district presidium has worked on a specific plan during these last two years. I am grateful for having gifted and faithful men to work with: Pastor Nathanael Scharf (1st VP), Pastor Mathew Pfeifer (2nd VP), and Pastor Eugene DeVries (Secretary). We usually meet monthly by video conference call and occasionally face to face. Our vision statement is as follows:

Values: *(What we value ...)*

- Evangelical doctrine and practice.
- Vibrant churches planning gospel ministry and outreach.
- Healthy called workers growing spiritually and professionally.
- Well-equipped circuit pastors and district leaders encouraging others.
- Congregations supporting the work of our synod.

Mission: *(Why we exist...)*

The Minnesota District Presidium supports congregations of our district and their leaders in biblical ministry.

Vision: *(What do we want to be...)*

The Minnesota District of WELS is a vibrant group of congregations with ...

- leaders that are personally rooted in the Word, and,
- well-trained and well-balanced spiritual leaders collaborating to carry out Jesus' Great Commission with up-to-date and realistic strategic plans, and,
- Christ-centered, engaging and edifying worship and spiritual growth programs, and,
- regular and effective outreach to "the lost," well-rounded biblical stewardship, strong support for missions, and,
- good communication with their members and in their community,

Leadership training of people in our districts

We believe that circuit pastors are important in providing counseling and leadership to the pastors, teachers and congregations of our district. To that end, we have training for our circuit pastors every year in early November and hold quarterly video conferences to address current issues and review progress toward our long-range goals.

- We have provided a cloud-based reporting site on our synod's database, where circuit pastors can report their visits to pastors and congregations. These reports are visible to the district presidium.
- During the summer months of each year, we organize a retreat with the pastors and their wives who have completed their first year in parish ministry. This retreat is an opportunity for the presidium to listen to the blessings and challenges experienced in their first year of parish service, provide counsel and encouragement, review best practices for congregation administration, and discuss maintaining appropriate work/family life balance.
- The presidium continues to partner with Mr. David Gartner (MN District Schools Coordinator) to engage school law expert, Sam Nelson. Several workshops were held with administrators and leaders of district high schools, elementary schools, and early childhood ministries to review handbooks and policies for compliance with state laws as well as identify prudent and imprudent verbiage inclusion or exclusion in staff, parent, and student policy handbooks. Sound policies reduce the likelihood of litigation and conflicts that sap their time and energy. Our goal is for administrators and leaders to focus as much as possible on our mission of sharing the gospel with blood-bought souls.

Appointments

When an elected position becomes vacant between district conventions, it is the responsibility of the presidium to appoint qualified individuals to complete the outgoing member's term of service. In the past biennium the district presidium made the following appointments.

- Pastor Roger Rockhoff – MN District MCG Chairman (09/18/24)
- Pastor Robert Harting – MN District Constitution Committee (09/18/24)
- Pastor Stephen Schmiel – MN District Mission Board Chairman (02/15/25)
- Pastor Brian Schmidt – MN District Mission Board (08/13/25)
- Pastor Jesse DeDeyne – MN District Constitution Committee Chairman (04/24/26)

Our Two Year Goals

Develop Best Practices for LES/ECE ministries Leadership training in our district

- Build leadership in schools (principals, ECE Directors)
- Conferences for ECE directors / administrators based on principal conference model
- Encourage & train congregations in Ministry Planning

School sustainability

- Identify financially sustainable models to help schools thrive.
- Provide children's ministry harvest strategies

Leadership Training Module for Pastors

- Under development by Pastor Brian Kom a lay leader who is a General Electric executive

- Piloted with young pastors in the Rochester area.
- Will be presented to the circuit pastors at the November conference.

Facilitate Ministry Cooperation Meetings

“Two are better than one, because they have a good return for their labor” Ecclesiastes 4:9. The MN District Presidium believes there are opportunities for congregations and schools to partner to do more and better gospel ministry. To that end, we continue to schedule meeting with groups of congregations in rural and urban communities to explore the following:

- How we can be better stewards of the current number of called workers in our district. (WELS has more pastors per communicants than ever before in its history.)
- How we can merge, realign, or band together to regain critical mass for sustainable ministry where it has been lost.
- How we can share specialized gifts of lay members and called workers beyond their local congregations and schools.

In May three congregations along the Hwy 212 corridor voted to merge: Zion, Olivia; St. Matthew, Danube; St. John, Renville. This took place as a result of consultation and partnership with WELS Congregational Services. Mt. Olive, St. Paul, MN also utilized WELS Congregational Services to develop a long-range ministry plan. Their work resulted in Mt. Olive receiving Mission Enhancement support from the WELS Board for Home Missions.

What We Hope to Do With God’s Blessings

Child Abuse Prevention Resources

Let no debt remain outstanding, except the continuing debt to love one another (Ro 13:8). Our obligation to love our neighbor extends to the vulnerable. Loving them includes protecting them. Reports of abuse are frequent in headlines, even in the spaces that ought to be the safest, even in our circles. We have an obligation to love and protect these little ones for whom Christ died. To have policies in place is a must, even for congregations that don’t have schools. To follow those policies is a must, not just for legal protection, but for the protection of the vulnerable.

On page 36 of the RTTD, WELS Congregational Services reports on their efforts to produce a comprehensive suite of resources to help Lutheran congregations and schools create the safest possible environment for children and youth.

To this end, the Minnesota Twin Cities Principal Group is holding a work Workshop on Tuesday, August 11, 2026, at St. Croix Lutheran Academy. To assist with lunch planning, **one person from each participating congregation is asked to complete the registration form** at the following link: <https://forms.gle/gfrpyfTXLyKoT3HN9>

Training Overview

Victor Vieth will present on the important topic of child abuse prevention and response. His session will cover:

- Survivor accounts and indicators used to identify child abuse
- Recommended policies for staff handbooks and procedures to follow when concerns arise
- Current research and data related to child abuse prevention and response

Victor is a WELS member at St. John's Lutheran Church in Lewiston, Minnesota, and recommends this workshop for:

- School leaders
- Called workers
- Classroom aides
- Church staff
- Any individuals who work directly with students

This training will provide valuable insights, practical guidance, and resources to help ministries better protect and serve the children entrusted to their care.

Pastor Evaluations

As a fruit of faith in our Savior, we strive to serve him and others to the best of our ability. This applies doubly to those who are called to shepherd God's saints. A pastor is not on the receiving end of his ministry. As a result, he can have blind spots related to the allocation of his time to particular ministry tasks, an inaccurate perception of how he is relating to others or not realize how appreciative the congregation is of his faithful work. The Minnesota District website has posted a [Pastor Evaluation](#) tool available to assist congregation leaders in a pastoral review process. Those who engage in this constructive review will find that it builds trust and unity between the congregation leaders and pastor as they partner together to proclaim Christ-for-us in their congregations and community.

Governance Samples

The Conference of Presidents has approved three new church governance samples for congregations to consider. These samples:

- foster greater consensus building regarding major ministry decisions
- reduce the number of regular voters meetings, empower the ministry council and boards to take greater ownership of their ministry oversight
- provide greater opportunities to utilize the gifts of women in congregation management roles.
- (Oversight roles are those that involve the exercise of headship over men. Management roles are focused on executing ministry tasks that do not involve headship over men.)

These samples can be accessed via this [LINK](#) located on the Resource Page of the welsmn.org website.

Conference of Presidents:

Congregational Mission Offerings (CMO)

The Lord has blessed the WELS with a variety of revenue streams that financially support the work we do together as a church body. Congregational Mission Offerings are the bread and butter. They are the most predictable and reliable source of the funding of our home missions, our world missions, our worker training system, and Congregational Services.

After remaining flat for a decade, CMOs have been rising synod-wide since 2020. In 2025 CMO exceeded \$24 million. All glory be to God alone!

There are, however, two concerning trends. One is that the increase in CMO has not kept pace with inflation. The dollars coming in are increasing, but the purchasing power of those dollars is decreasing at a faster rate. The other trend is that, synod-wide, CMO represents a declining share of total congregational giving. Pastor Jon Hein shares in his report in the RTTD, “Total offerings in WELS increased by 6.3% in 2025, suggesting strong congregational generosity even amid inflationary pressure. Yet [CMOs], which support the shared ministry of the synod, rose by just 0.1% over the same period” (p 40).

We rightly teach our people to give in proportion to their own means, not in proportion to the means of others. We do well to model that as congregations. We likely also teach our people that the Old Testament tithe in support of the Levites can serve as a good rule of thumb for the Christian to apply in freedom. Can we aim for the same as congregations? I can assure you without any doubt that **God is able to bless you abundantly, so that in all things at all times, having all that you need, you will abound in every good work** (2Co 9:8).

A facet of our CMO giving where I see room for improvement is in remittance. Please send CMO checks monthly—at the very least quarterly. It so easily falls off the radar. If negligence to remit isn’t noticed until the end of the year, it can be an unexpected blow to account balances.

You might consider these options for timely remittance:

- Recurring EFT: The withdrawal amount can only be changed once each year for the new year. To change the amount, contact Michelle Henrichsen in WELS Financial Services at michelle.henrichsen@wels.net or 414-256-3257.
- Bill pay is acceptable if the check includes your five-digit church ID and “CMO 2026.” Send to the WELS Center for Mission and Ministry, N16W23377 Stone Ridge Dr, Waukesha, WI 53188, **not** the P.O. Box address used for coupon payments.

When it comes to setting CMO subscriptions and ensuring remittance of CMO checks, perhaps the only person in a congregation more influential than the pastor is the president or elder. God bless your evangelical encouragements to excel in the grace of giving!

Transitions in district and synod presidencies

Since district presidents (DPs) serve two-year terms, every biennium there are elections for district presidents across our church body. This June there are five district presidents who are not standing for re-election: Pastor **Doug Free** of the Dakota-Montana District, Pastor **Phil Hirsch** of the Nebraska

District, Pastor **Don Patterson** of the South Central District, Pastor **Chuck Westra** of the South Atlantic District, and Pastor **Joel Zank** of the Northern Wisconsin District.

Synod officers serve four-year terms. Next year, synod president **Mark Schroeder** plans to retire after serving twenty years as president of the WELS. The next synod president will be called by election at the 2027 synod convention. In accordance with a [change in the WELS bylaws](#), synod convention delegates will nominate candidates before the convention. This will allow delegates to learn about the nominees beforehand, and it will allow the nominees the opportunity to consider the possibility of serving in such a way. cf. RTTD, p 5.

I thank God for giving me the opportunity of serving alongside all these men. They've been wonderful role models of pastoral leadership.

Appointment to the Synodical Council

The Conference of Presidents (COP) could be compared to a board of elders for the WELS. The Synodical Council (SC) could be compared to a church council. Three DPs serve as voting members of the SC. All three of them conclude their service this month. At its April meeting the COP chose Joel Heckendorf of the Arizona-California District, Michael Seifert of the North Atlantic District, and me to succeed Joel Zank, Phil Hirsch, and Chuck Westra.

May 2026 Assignment Committee Meetings

Wisconsin Lutheran Seminary numbers

- 108 requests for pastoral candidates
- 46 candidates available (compared with 24 in 2025!), plus 3 reassigned and 3 PSI candidates
- All candidates were assigned, bringing pastoral vacancies synod-wide down to 128, a 10% vacancy rate. (This is down from a post-assignment peak of 146 vacancies in 2024.)
- 42 vicars were assigned.
- The 2027 graduating class of WLS is in the mid-30s.

Martin Luther College numbers

- 156 requests for teacher candidates
- 49 candidates who were not geographically limited by marriage or other factors
- 79 candidates were assigned, plus 17 reassigned to their current position
- 88 teacher requests went unfilled
- Synod-wide, at least 110 teacher vacancies remain
- 3 staff minister candidates; all 3 were assigned

Minnesota District numbers

- 6 traditional WLS graduates assigned:
 - Bouk Chuol to Crown of Life, West St. Paul, MN
 - John Wendland to Christ, North St. Paul/Hugo, MN
 - Ronnie Nguyen to Mt. Olive, St. Paul, MN

- John Fix to Christ Alone, Dardenne Prairie, MO
- Dallas Biga to Calvary, Glenwood/St. John, Hancock, MN
- Jack Heichelbech to Martin Luther College, New Ulm, MN
- 1 Pastoral Studies Institute graduate assigned
 - Alexander Xiong to Holy Trinity, New Hope, MN
- 6 teacher candidates were assigned to MN District
 - Morgan Ritter (ECE) to Trinity, Nicollet, MN
 - Paige Mathiowetz (ECE) to God's Treasures (Zion), Winthrop, MN
 - Sandra Hahnke (Grades 1-2) to Trinity, Belle Plaine, MN
 - Lily Schultz (Grades 1-2) to Holy Trinity, New Hope, MN
 - Rachel Schoeneck (Grade 7) to St. John, Redwood Falls, MN
 - Annemarie Backus (Grades 3-5) to St. Mark, Bemidji, MN
- Vacancies remaining after assignments
 - 21 parish pastor positions
 - 5 elementary teacher positions
 - 3 ECE teacher positions
 - 1 staff minister position

WELS Ministry Certification

- From July 2024 through May 2026, 9 WELS members not WELS teacher certified through Martin Luther College received and accepted provisional calls to serve in district schools.
- Noncertified candidates seeking provisional call status must complete the eligibility process with the district president and agree to complete the WELS Ministry Certification Program through Martin Luther College.
- All WELS Ministry Certification courses are available online.
- Enrollment in the WELS Ministry Certification Program (WMCP) qualifies provisionally called teachers for Minister of the Gospel tax status with the IRS. Teachers not enrolled in the WMCP do not qualify and calling bodies must withhold FICA from their wages.

MN DISTRICT STATISTICS

- | | |
|------------------------------------|-------------------------------------|
| • Congregations = 149 | • Staff Ministers Active = 5 |
| • Early Childhood Ministries = 42 | • Teachers Active = 323 |
| • Lutheran Elementary Schools = 29 | • Total Called Workers Active = 477 |
| • Area Lutheran High Schools = 4 | • Communicant Members = 32,176 |
| • Pastors Active = 149 | |

WELSource Reminder:

1. **Retired Called Workers:** Please take some time to update your information as well. Retired pastor John Seifert is working with the synod to keep the retired people's willingness to serve updated. This is to assist the COP as it seeks retired people to serve in part-time roles.
2. **Personal Biography Information:** A Personal Biography link is available to all WELS Called Workers via My WELS Cloud (<http://cloud.wels.net/me>).
3. **Self-Assessment Forms:** All Called workers, please take a moment to update your WELS Cloud profile to ensure it reflects the most current information. Please refer to our updating help document <https://wels.bmetrack.com/> for details.
4. **Teacher Forms:** Information and instructions regarding the forms are available in the General Documents folder on the Lutheran Schools Resource Center (<http://cls.welsrc.net>). If you need to request an account, go to <http://account.wels.net>. When prompted for a request code, please enter CWI. Once your account has been established you will receive an email that contains your login information.

MN District Called Worker Changes

2025-2026 PASTORS ASSIGNED:

*Rev. Christopher Gorr	Shepherd of the Lakes Lutheran Church, Fairmont, MN
*Rev. JonAlden Pedersen	Salem Lutheran Church, Stillwater, MN
*Rev. Malachi Mortensen	Martin Luther College, New Ulm, MN
*Rev. Zachary Flunker	Mount Olive Lutheran Church, Delano, MN
*Rev. Buok Chuol	Crown of Life Lutheran Church, West St. Paul, MN
*Rev. John Wendland	Christ Lutheran Church, North St. Paul/Hugo, MN
*Rev. John Fix	Christ Alone Lutheran Church, West St. Paul, MN
*Rev. Dallas Biga	St. John Lutheran Church, Hancock/Calvary Lutheran Church, Glenwood, MN
*Rev. Ronnie Nguyen	Mount Olive Lutheran Church, St. Paul, MN
*Rev. Alexander Xiong	Holy Trinity Lutheran Church, New Hope, MN

2025-2026 TEACHERS ASSIGNED

Mrs. Morgan Ritter	God's Treasures ECE, Winthrop, MN 2025 Trinity Lutheran School, Nicollet, MN 2026
*Mr. Alexander Ritter	Trinity Lutheran School, Nicollet, MN
Miss Grace Seim	Trinity Lutheran School Belle Plaine, MN
*Mr. Colin Krueger	Bloomington/Living Hope Lutheran School, Bloomington, MN
Miss Madelyn Plitzweit	Bloomington/Living Hope Lutheran School, Bloomington, MN
Miss Anastasia Scharf	St. Paul's Lutheran School, Arlington, MN
Mrs. Emma Dorn	St. Paul's Lutheran School, New Ulm, MN
Miss Hope Sulzle	Immanuel/Grace Lutheran School, Hutchinson, MN

Miss Emmaline Hagedorn	St. John Lutheran School, Caledonia, MN
Miss Meg Stangl	St. Paul's Lutheran School, Cannon Falls, MN
Miss Kylie Wolff	St. John Lutheran School, Lake City, MN
*Mr. Cory Deyo	Christ Lutheran School, Marshall, MN
Miss Paige Mathiowetz	God's Treasures ECE, Winthrop, MN
Mrs. Sandra Hahnke	Trinity Lutheran School, Belle Plaine, MN
Miss Lily Schultz	Holy Trinity Lutheran School, New Hope, MN
Miss Rachel Schoeneck	St. John Lutheran School, Redwood Falls, MN
Miss Annemarie Backus	St. Mark Lutheran School, Bemidji, MN

*These are accepted into the membership of the Minnesota District.

A. PASTOR CALLS ACCEPTED INTO AND WITHIN THE DISTRICT

Name	Start Date	Calling Body
Rev. Bradley Snyder	7/1/2024	St Croix Lutheran Academy, West Saint Paul, MN
Rev. Collin Wenzel	7/1/2024	Christ Our Rock Lutheran Church, Rochester, MN
Rev. Isaac Cherney	7/1/2024	West Lutheran High School, Plymouth, MN
Rev. Joel Hansen	7/1/2024	Bloomington Lutheran Church, Bloomington, MN
Rev. Noah Hartmann	7/1/2024	St Paul's Lutheran Church, North Mankato, MN
Rev. Peter Leyrer	7/1/2024	Emmanuel Lutheran Church, Hudson, WI
Rev. Ethan Boese	9/1/2024	St John's Lutheran Church, Dakota, MN
Rev. Adam Pilarski	11/10/2024	First Lutheran Church, La Crescent, MN
Rev. David Brandt	1/1/2025	Grace Lutheran Church, Oronoco, MN
Rev. Samuel Crass	1/1/2025	St Paul Lutheran Church, Prescott, WI
Rev. Stephen Kuehl	1/1/2025	Minnesota Valley Lutheran High School, New Ulm, MN
Rev. Erik Lund	5/9/2025	St John Lutheran Church, Lake Benton, MN
Rev. Bruce Janisch	6/1/2025	Mt Olive Lutheran Church, Delano, MN
Rev. Matthew Nowak	6/2/2025	Anchored in Christ Lutheran Ministries-Greenfield and Rockford MN
Rev. Brian Weinkauff	7/1/2025	Petra Lutheran Church, Sauk Rapids, MN
Rev. Seth Krueger	10/1/2025	Divinity Lutheran Church, Saint Paul, MN
Rev. Todd Krueger	11/1/2025	Zion Lutheran Church, Springfield, MO
*Rev. Cory Hahnke		Grace Lutheran Church, South St. Paul, MN

B. TEACHER & STAFF MINISTER CALLS ACCEPTED INTO AND WITHIN THE DISTRICT

Name	Start Date	Calling Body
Dr. Susan Decker	07/01/2024	Martin Luther College, New Ulm, MN
Miss Alyssa Walther	07/01/2024	Holy Trinity Lutheran Academy, New Hope, MN
Miss Brooke Berlin	11/22/2024	Christ Lutheran School, North Saint Paul, MN
Miss Catherine Backer	07/01/2026	Good Shepherd Lutheran School, Burnsville, MN
Miss Courtney Wegwerth	07/01/2025	Good Shepherd Lutheran School, Burnsville, MN

Miss Emmaline Miller	07/01/2025	St John Lutheran School, Caledonia, MN
Miss Grace Cook	07/01/2024	St Paul Lutheran School, Saint James, MN
Miss Hannah Koss	07/01/2025	Good Shepherd Lutheran School, Burnsville, MN
Miss Jamie Chambers	07/01/2025	Mt Olive Lutheran School, Mankato, MN
Miss Johanna Fischer	07/01/2025	MLC Early Childhood Learning Center, New Ulm, MN
Miss Kylie Wolf	07/01/2025	St John Lutheran School, Lake City, MN
Miss Lisa Hoffer	07/01/2024	St John Lutheran School, Lake City, MN
Miss Lynsey Marohn	07/01/2024	Building Blocks Early Learning Center, Cambridge, MN
Miss Madeline Abel	07/01/2024	Good Shepherd Lutheran School, Burnsville, MN
Miss Michaela Bubolz	07/01/2024	Christ Lutheran School, Zumbrota, MN
Miss Rebecca Gervais	07/01/2025	Christ Lutheran School, North Saint Paul, MN
Miss Rebecca Hagglund	08/26/2024	Roots to Wings Learning Center, Lake City, MN
Miss Samantha Schoch	07/01/2024	St Croix Lutheran Academy, West Saint Paul, MN
Miss Tatiana Parker	07/01/2024	Crown of Life Lutheran School, West Saint Paul, MN
Mr. Adam Stevens	07/01/2024	Risen Savior Lutheran School, Mankato, MN
Mr. Alexander Braun	07/22/2024	St John Lutheran School, Lewiston, MN
Mr. Alexander Ritter	07/01/2025	Trinity Lutheran School, Nicollet, MN
Mr. Andrew Danner	07/01/2025	Bloomington Lutheran School, Bloomington, MN
Mr. Andrew Grady	07/01/2024	St Croix Lutheran Academy, West Saint Paul, MN
Mr. Andrew Kramer	07/01/2025	St Croix Lutheran Academy, West Saint Paul, MN
Mr. Andrew Kramer	07/01/2025	St Croix Lutheran Academy, West Saint Paul, MN
Mr. Andrew Mantz	07/01/2024	Christ Lutheran School, North Saint Paul, MN
Mr. Benjamin Haferman	07/01/2024	Resurrection Lutheran Church, Rochester, MN
*Mr. Colin Krueger	07/01/2025	Bloomington Lutheran School, Bloomington, MN
*Mr. Corey Deyo	07/01/2025	Samuel Lutheran School, Marshall, MN
Mr. Daniel Zabel	07/01/2024	St John Lutheran School, Caledonia, MN
Mr. David Liebhard	07/01/2024	St Croix Lutheran Academy, West Saint Paul, MN
Mr. David Mielke	07/01/2024	Crown of Life Lutheran School, West Saint Paul, MN
Mr. Dyllan Jensen	07/01/2025	Christ Lutheran School, North Saint Paul, MN
Mr. Elijah Dorn	07/01/2024	Minnesota Valley Lutheran High School, New Ulm, MN
Mr. Hayden Miller	07/01/2025	St John Lutheran School, Redwood Falls, MN
Mr. Isaiah Loersch	07/01/2024	Immanuel Grace Lutheran School, Hutchinson, MN
Mr. James Bohn	07/01/2024	St Croix Lutheran Academy, West Saint Paul, MN
Mr. Jefferson Heyer	07/01/2024	Samuel Lutheran School, Marshall, MN
Mr. Joshua Wong	07/01/2025	West Lutheran High School, Plymouth, MN
Mr. Justin Hansen	07/01/2025	St Paul's Lutheran School, New Ulm, MN

Mr. Justin Wiechmann	07/01/2024	St Peter Lutheran School, Saint Peter, MN
Mr. Kincaid Diersen	07/01/2024	St Croix Lutheran Academy, West Saint Paul, MN
Mr. Matthew Doering	07/01/2025	Martin Luther College, New Ulm, MN
*Mr. Micah Degner	07/01/2025	Minnesota Valley Lutheran High School, New Ulm, MN
Mr. Noah Ungemach	07/01/2024	Minnesota Valley Lutheran High School, New Ulm, MN
Mr. Paul Bases	07/01/2024	Martin Luther College, New Ulm, MN
Mr. Paul Heldman	08/21/2024	Anchored in Christ Lutheran Ministries-Greenfield and Rockford MN, Loretto, MN
Mr. Phil Sundblad	07/01/2024	St Croix Lutheran Academy, West Saint Paul, MN
Mr. Riley Hillstrom	07/01/2024	St Croix Lutheran Academy, West Saint Paul, MN
*Mr. Robert Cahow	07/01/2025	Holy Trinity Lutheran Academy, New Hope, MN
Mr. Rollin Timm	07/01/2025	Minnesota Valley Lutheran High School, New Ulm, MN
Mr. Ryan Randall	07/01/2025	Holy Trinity Lutheran Academy, New Hope, MN
Mr. Shawn Herkstroeter	07/01/2024	Grace in Action, New Ulm, MN
Mr. Timothy Voigt	07/01/2025	Crown of Life Lutheran School, West Saint Paul, MN
Mr. Wolf Parsons	06/01/2024	Resurrection Lutheran School, Rochester, MN
Mrs. Abby Plocher	07/01/2025	St Croix Lutheran Academy, West Saint Paul, MN
Mrs. Abby Zuberbier	07/01/2024	St Croix Lutheran Academy, West Saint Paul, MN
Mrs. Allison Stevens	07/01/2024	Mt Olive Lutheran School, Delano, MN
Mrs. Alydia Zemke	08/12/2024	St John Lutheran School, Lake City, MN
Mrs. Amanda Ofstie	07/01/2024	Mt Olive Lutheran School, Delano, MN
Mrs. Anastasia Thomas	07/01/2025	St Paul Lutheran School, Arlington, MN
Mrs. Andrea Cherney	07/01/2024	Ascension Lutheran Preschool, Plymouth, MN
Mrs. Andrea Spanovich	07/01/2026	Samuel Lutheran School, Marshall, MN
Mrs. Angela Randall	07/01/2024	West Lutheran High School, Plymouth, MN
Mrs. Anna Gartner	07/01/2025	West Lutheran High School, Plymouth, MN
Mrs. Anna Heins	07/01/2025	St John Lutheran School, Lake City, MN
Mrs. Anna Schaefer	07/01/2026	St Paul's Lutheran School, New Ulm, MN
Mrs. April Marquardt	07/01/2025	St Croix Lutheran Academy, West Saint Paul, MN
Mrs. Ashley Olsen	10/26/2025	Mt Olive Lutheran School, Mankato, MN
Mrs. Carin Schmiel	07/01/2024	Bloomington Lutheran School, Bloomington, MN
Mrs. Carol Aker	08/01/2024	Bloomington Lutheran School, Bloomington, MN
Mrs. Carolyn Kelly	07/01/2025	Trinity Lutheran School, Nicollet, MN
Mrs. Clara Handy	08/11/2025	God's Treasures Childcare Learning Center, Winthrop, MN
Mrs. Darla Werth	07/01/2025	Little Lambs Preschool, Baxter, MN
Mrs. Dawn Harting	07/01/2025	St Peter Lutheran School, Saint Peter, MN
Mrs. Dawn Martinson	04/01/2026	Living Hope Lutheran School, Shakopee, MN

Mrs. Deborah Weigand	07/01/2024	Christ Lutheran School, Zumbrota, MN
Mrs. Elizabeth Jensen	07/01/2025	Christ Lutheran School, North Saint Paul, MN
Mrs. Emily Mantz	07/01/2024	St Croix Lutheran Academy, West Saint Paul, MN
Mrs. Emma Dorn	07/01/2025	St Paul's Lutheran School, New Ulm, MN
Mrs. Erica Schlomer	07/01/2024	St Paul Lutheran School, Arlington, MN
Mrs. Grace Foster	07/01/2025	Trinity Lutheran School, Belle Plaine, MN
Mrs. Grace Weisensel	07/01/2024	God's Treasures Childcare Learning Center, Winthrop, MN
Mrs. Hannah Borgwardt	01/01/2025	St Paul Lutheran School, Arlington, MN
Mrs. Hannah Frick	07/01/2024	St Croix Lutheran Academy, West Saint Paul, MN
Mrs. Hannah Renner	07/01/2024	Trinity Lutheran School, Belle Plaine, MN
Mrs. Heidi Kutz	07/01/2025	St John Lutheran School, Dakota, MN
Mrs. Hope Horn	07/01/2025	Immanuel Grace Lutheran School, Hutchinson, MN
Mrs. Janet Justice	07/01/2024	Martin Luther College, New Ulm, MN
Mrs. Jessica Schmidt	06/01/2024	God's Treasures Childcare Learning Center, Winthrop, MN
Mrs. Jody Bitter	07/01/2024	St John Lutheran School, Goodhue, MN
Mrs. Karen Klindworth	07/01/2024	Resurrection Lutheran School and Preschool, Rochester, MN
Mrs. Karis Jensen	07/01/2025	Little Lambs Preschool, Baxter, MN
Mrs. Katherine Guldborg	07/01/2024	Good Shepherd Lutheran School, Burnsville, MN
Mrs. Kelly Heldman	07/01/2024	Mt Olive Lutheran School, Delano, MN
Mrs. Kirsten Larkin	07/01/2024	Bloomington Lutheran School, Bloomington, MN
Mrs. Kristen Lukasek	07/01/2024	Mt Olive Lutheran School, Mankato, MN
Mrs. Lisa Vieth	07/01/2025	St John Lutheran School, Lewiston, MN
Mrs. Lucinda Richardson	07/01/2024	St John Lutheran School, Redwood Falls, MN
Mrs. MacKenzie Holzbauer	07/01/2024	Martin Luther College, New Ulm, MN
Mrs. Madelyn Krueger	07/01/2024	Bloomington Lutheran School, Bloomington, MN
Mrs. Mandy Elseth	07/01/2025	Salem Preschool, Woodbury, MN
Mrs. Meg Diersen	07/01/2025	St Paul Lutheran School, Cannon Falls, MN
Mrs. Morgan Ritter	01/01/2026	God's Treasures Childcare Learning Center, Winthrop, MN
Mrs. Naomi Boerner	07/15/2024	Cross of Christ Lutheran School, Coon Rapids, MN
Mrs. Naomi Johnson	07/01/2024	God's Treasures Childcare Learning Center, Winthrop, MN
Mrs. Natalie Eckstein	07/01/2024	St Peter Lutheran School, Saint Peter, MN
Mrs. Nicole Dragt	07/01/2024	Immanuel Grace Lutheran School, Hutchinson, MN
Mrs. Rachel Hansen	07/01/2025	St Paul's Lutheran School, New Ulm, MN
Mrs. Rachel Markgraf	07/01/2025	Immanuel Grace Lutheran School, Hutchinson, MN
Mrs. Rebecca Raabe	07/01/2024	Good Shepherd Lutheran School, Burnsville, MN
Mrs. Renee Hussman	07/01/2026	Trinity Lutheran School, Nicollet, MN

Mrs. Sarah Gullixson	07/01/2025	St John Lutheran School, Redwood Falls, MN
Mrs. Sarah Krueger	01/01/2026	Christ Lutheran School, North Saint Paul, MN
Mrs. Sarah Strackbein	07/01/2025	St Paul's Lutheran School, New Ulm, MN
Mrs. Sarah Zahrt	07/01/2025	Minnesota Valley Lutheran High School, New Ulm, MN
Mrs. Shanna Kurbis	07/01/2024	Living Hope Lutheran School, Shakopee, MN
Mrs. Taylor Doering	07/01/2024	God's Treasures Childcare Learning Center, Winthrop, MN
Ms. Angela Pittman	07/01/2025	Anchored in Christ - Salem Lutheran School, Greenfield, MN
Ms. Ashley Koopman	07/01/2024	Mt Olive Lutheran School, Delano, MN
Ms. Julie Matzke	06/03/2024	God's Treasures Childcare Learning Center, Winthrop, MN
Ms. Kelsey Nimmer	07/01/2025	Good Shepherd Lutheran School, Burnsville, MN
Ms. Kristin Massman	07/01/2024	Bloomington Lutheran School, Bloomington, MN
Ms. Melissa Kuehn	07/01/2024	St John Lutheran School, Redwood Falls, MN
Ms. Naomi Barrott	04/01/2026	Living Hope Lutheran School, Shakopee, MN
Ms. Xinrui Xu	07/01/2024	St Croix Lutheran Academy, West Saint Paul, MN
Prof. Lori Unke	07/01/2024	St Croix Lutheran Academy, West Saint Paul, MN
Justin Hansen	06/30/2025	St. Paul's Lutheran School, New Ulm, MN
Rachel Hansen	06/30/2025	St. Paul's Lutheran School, New Ulm, MN

*These are presented below for acceptance into the voting membership of the Minnesota District.

C. PASTORS TRANSFERRED OUT OF THE DISTRICT		
Name	Date	District
Rev. Eugene Andrus	02/28/2026	Michigan
Rev. John Berg	09/22/2024	Northern Wisconsin
Rev. Lucas Callies	04/19/2025	Michigan
Rev. Nathan Cordes	06/30/2024	Southeastern Wisconsin
Rev. Timothy Denney	10/31/2024	Southeastern Wisconsin
Rev. Aaron Jensen	08/14/2025	Southeastern Wisconsin
Rev. Dominick Olson	02/28/2026	Pacific Northwest
Rev. Micah Plocher	06/30/2025	Nebraska
Rev. Nathaniel Savage	06/30/2025	Arizona/California
Rev. Wayne Schoch	08/31/2024	South Atlantic
Rev. Philip Schroeder	12/31/2024	Western Wisconsin
Rev. Daniel Slaughter	05/31/2026	Southeastern Wisconsin
Rev. Peter Sulzle	07/31/2024	Arizona/California
Rev. Steven Waldschmidt	04/30/2025	Northern Wisconsin
Rev. Paul Welke	09/30/2024	Western Wisconsin
Rev. Benjamin Zamzow	08/31/2025	Arizona/California
Rev. Paul Kuehn	05/05/2026	Evangelical Lutheran Synod

D. TEACHERS & STAFF MINISTERS TRANSFERRED OUT		
Name	Date	District
Brett Bengel	06/30/2025	Northern Wisconsin
Rebecca Hagglund	06/30/2025	Northern Wisconsin
Debbie Hansen	06/30/2025	South Atlantic
Erin Laabs	06/30/2025	Southeastern Wisconsin
Nathan Menges	06/30/2024	South Central
Kathleen Mildebrandt	06/30/2025	Northern Wisconsin
Paul Mildebrandt	06/30/2025	Northern Wisconsin
Kari Munte	06/30/2025	Northern Wisconsin
Christopher Olson	06/30/2025	Western Wisconsin
Lynette Olson	06/30/2025	Western Wisconsin
Emily Platzer	06/30/2025	Southeastern Wisconsin
David Retzlaff	06/30/2024	Southeastern Wisconsin
Sara Rieke	06/30/2024	Arizona/California
Carol Schoenherr	06/30/2025	Northern Wisconsin
Jeffrey Schoenherr	06/30/2025	Northern Wisconsin
Kyle Seim	06/30/2024	Northern Wisconsin
Catherine St. John	06/30/2025	Southeastern Wisconsin
Nicole Tranberg	06/30/2024	Northern Wisconsin
Justin Vilski	06/30/2024	Nebraska
Justin Wasser	06/30/2025	Michigan
Justin Wiechmann	06/30/2025	Michigan
David Zabel	06/30/2024	Pacific Northwest
Isaiah Loersch	06/30/2025	Southeastern Wisconsin
Joseph Nash	06/30/2024	Dakota/Montana
Hannah Renner	06/30/2025	Southeastern Wisconsin
Abigail Robbert	06/30/2024	Southeastern Wisconsin
Daniel Zabel	06/30/2025	Pacific Northwest
Jefferson Heyer	06/30/2025	Arizona/California
Sophia Scheuerlein	06/30/2024	Southeastern Wisconsin
Alyssa Schroeder	06/30/2024	Western Wisconsin

F. Teacher & Staff Minister Resignations	
Name	Date
Brooke Berlin	11/21/2024
Kelli Green	08/15/2024
Rebecca Ungemach	06/30/2024
Alydia Zemke	12/31/2024
Andrea Spanovich	06/30/2024

Hannah Borgwardt	06/30/2025
Taylor Doering	05/22/2025
Erica Schlomer	12/31/2024
Annette Schultz	06/30/2024
Allison Hofland	08/08/2024
Erin Laabs	06/30/2024
Alison Moeri	08/16/2024
Alyssa Walther	05/31/2026
Anna White	06/30/2025
Adrienne Bengel	06/30/2025
Brooke Berlin	08/20/2025
Katrina Bohn	06/30/2024
Katherine Guldborg	12/18/2025
Sarah Higgins	06/30/2024
Lorna Kapanke	06/30/2024
Theodore Klug	10/09/2025
Jonathan Laabs	06/30/2024
Brittany Lebert	06/30/2024
Sora Lee	06/30/2025
Hayden Miller	12/19/2025
Wolf Parsons	03/07/2025
Terese Redders	06/30/2024
Maria Reese	06/30/2024
Madison Schneider	06/30/2025
Charlotte Schoch	06/30/2024
Katherine VandenBosch	12/31/2025
Kellsie Wasser	06/30/2025
Grace Weisensel	02/06/2026
Kelly Welsh	06/30/2024
Susan Zabel	06/30/2024

G. Pastor Retirements

Name		Date
David Huebner	06/30/2024	
Jonathan Ladner	06/30/2024	
Allen Lonnquist	07/31/2024	
Paul Marggraf	12/31/2024	
James Bourman	01/01/2025	
Thomas Nass	06/30/2025	
Rodney Pudell	06/30/2024	
Mark Rieke	06/30/2024	
John Unnasch	08/31/2025	

Roger Neumann	05/31/2026
Brian Dose	06/30/2026

H. Teacher & Staff Minister Retirements

Name	Date
Paul Bases	06/30/2024
Carol Aker	06/30/2025
Cheryl Loomis	06/30/2025
Sandra Brauer	06/30/2025
Jeffrey Schultz	12/31/2024
Rollin Timm	06/30/2025
Lori Unke	06/30/2024
James Dretske	12/30/2025
Lyle Strehler	06/30/2025
Barb Becker	12/31/2024
Mark Dobberstein	06/30/2025
Sandra Dobberstein	06/30/2025
Richard Gibson	12/31/2025
Beth Hauf	06/30/2025
Jeanine Heller	06/30/2024
Robert Klindworth	06/30/2024
Jeffrey Koepsell	06/30/2024
Joyce Lendt	06/30/2025
Cliss Loescher	06/30/2025
Margaret Marggraf	06/30/2024
Rebecca Marti	06/30/2025
William Pekrul	06/30/2025
Ellen Pieper	06/30/2024
Cynthia Ring	06/30/2025
Cheryl Streckert	06/30/2025
Mark Tacke	06/30/2025
Paul Weihing	06/30/2024
Daniel Whitney	06/30/2025
Beth Wolf	06/30/2025
John Festerling	06/30/2024
James Grunwald	06/30/2025

I. Called Workers Called to Glory While Residing in the MN District

Name	Date
Dr. John R. Isch	03/25/2026
Miss Rhoda M. Arndt	05/27/2025
Mr. Ronald A. Pape	12/20/2025
Mr. Arden W. Wentzel	04/04/2026
Mr. Steven F. Groening	06/25/2024
Mr. Paul J. Fritze	07/02/2024
Mr. Dale E. Markgraf	05/30/2025
Mr. Arthur L. Hackbarth	06/04/2025
Mr. Frederick H. Panning	11/12/2025
Mr. David P. Silfies	05/13/2026
Mrs. Barbara Herzog	05/10/2026
Mrs. Marcia M. Matthees	09/20/2024
Mrs. Ruth E. Strackbein	01/27/2025
Mrs. Lois I. Schrimpf	03/27/2025
Mrs. Joan D. Pinske	12/27/2025
Mrs. Ann M. Rautenberg	03/18/2026
Prof em. Rolland R. Menk	08/16/2024
Rev. Dale W. Schlieuwe	12/01/2025
Rev. William W. Ziebell	07/17/2024
Rev. Mark F. Zander	12/16/2024
Rev. James W. Lindloff	07/19/2025
Rev. John P. Gaertner	11/14/2025
Rev. Robert Carter	01/03/2026
Rev. Paul G. Heiderich	03/29/2026

J. MN District Congregations Closed

Name	Date
Good Shepherd Lutheran Church, Pipestone, MN	05/08/2025
Shepherd of the Hills Lutheran Church, Inver Grove Heights, MN	11/16/2025
Peace Lutheran Church, O'Fallon, IL	03/04/2026

K. MN District Schools Closed

Name	Date
St. Paul's Lutheran School, Cannon Falls, MN	06/30/2026

MN District News: To receive news and event notifications please subscribe to the MN District e-mail list at www.welsmn.org.

Serving Jesus and his saints,

Rev. Dennis C. Klatt

Rev. Dennis C. Klatt – WELS Minnesota District President

Subject: District Membership

Reference: District President's Report

Resolution No. 01

WHEREAS Pastors Christopher Gorr, Malachi Mortensen, JonAlden Petersen, and Zachary Flunker have been ordained and installed as pastors in the Minnesota District in the past biennium; and

WHEREAS Pastor Cory Hahnke's transfer from the ministerium of the Evangelical Lutheran Synod to the Minnesota District has been received, therefore be it

Resolved that Pastors Christopher Gorr, Malachi Mortensen, JonAlden Petersen, Zachary Flunker and Cory Hahnke be graciously welcomed into the voting membership of the Minnesota District of the Wisconsin Evangelical Lutheran Synod.

Resolution No. 02

WHEREAS Pastors-elect Dallas Biga, Buok Chuol, John Fix, Jack Heichelbech, Ronnie Nguyen, John Wendland and Alexander Xiong have received and accepted assignment into the Minnesota District; and

WHEREAS they have not yet been ordained and installed into the pastoral office, but plan to be later this summer; therefore be it

Resolved that Pastors-elect Dallas Biga, Buok Chuol, John Fix, Jack Heichelbech, Ronnie Nguyen, John Wendland and Alexander Xiong be graciously welcomed into the voting membership of the Minnesota District of the Wisconsin Evangelical Lutheran Synod, pending their respective ordinations and installations later this summer.

Resolution No. 03

WHEREAS the CRM status of Paul Kuehn was restored by the MN District Presidium; and

WHEREAS Paul subsequently received and accepted a call to serve in the Evangelical Lutheran Synod (ELS); and

WHEREAS the MN District Presidium, at his request, granted him a transfer of membership to the ministerium of the ELS; therefore be it

Resolved that the Minnesota District ratify Paul Kuehn's membership transfer to the ELS.

Resolution No. 04

WHEREAS Robert Cahow, Micah Degner, Colin Krueger, Alexander Ritter, and Cory Deyo were installed as teachers in the Minnesota District in the past biennium; therefore be it

Resolved that Robert Cahow, Micah Degner, Colin Krueger, Alexander Ritter, and Cory Deyo be graciously welcomed into the voting membership of the Minnesota District of the Wisconsin Evangelical Lutheran Synod.

Resolution No. 05

- WHEREAS Risen Savior Lutheran Church, North Liberty, IA has been officially incorporated with the State of Iowa; and
- WHEREAS Risen Savior's constitution and bylaws have been approved by the MN District Constitution Committee; and
- WHEREAS Risen Savior has applied for membership in the Minnesota District of the WELS; therefore be it
- Resolved that Risen Savior, North Liberty, IA be graciously welcomed as a member congregation of the Minnesota District of the Wisconsin Evangelical Lutheran Synod.